

A circular wreath of various botanical illustrations, including ferns, red and green leaves, orange flowers, and purple flowers, surrounding a central white circle.

Vers l'infini(tif) et Au-delà: Identifying Finiteness in Creoles

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Outline



Context of Study

Theoretical Approach

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Conclusion

Martinican and Haitian creoles

- MC and HC are French-based creoles.
Lexically related, syntactically closely related.
- SVO languages
- Morphologically reduced languages : TMA markers expressed as separate morphemes /
No morphological gender or number marking on nouns and adjectives.

The mom lik^{ed} her son^s – La maman aim^{ait} ses fil^s

[MC] Manman-lan ^{té} enmen ^{sé} tchanmay-li ^a

[HC] Manman an ^{te} renmen pitit li ^{yo}





Motivations

“Since it apparently contains no clauses that must be analyzed as nonfinite, the most parsimonious grammar of Saramaccan will generate only finite clauses.” Bickerton 1984, p.180

“The finite/nonfinite distinction is disputable in Atlantic IEPC’s [...] Either the facts that have been associated with putative distinction are not adequately accounted for or they can be described without unnecessarily complicating the grammar with it.” Mufwene & Dijkhoff 1989 p.325

“The process of pidginization involved loss of inflections in general and re-interpretation of some forms, including those of finite and nonfinite verbs. [...] So the verbs of Atlantic IEPC’s [...] are neither finite nor nonfinite. [...] these languages have devised other strategies to convey what their lexifiers convey through the infinitive” Mufwene & Dijkhoff 1989, p.325

“Il ne semble pas utile de distinguer dans les créoles français entre des formes verbales finies, donc tensées, et des formes non finies [...] Je conclurai qu’il n’existe ni infinitif ni participe dans les créoles français mais une grande diversité d’emplois transcatégoriels.” Véronique 2007





Motivations

1. Finiteness tied to inflectional morphology (finite vs. infinitive verb forms).
 - Infinitive verb form/nonfinite clauses vs. finite verb form/finite clauses
2. Creole languages have little to no inflectional morphology (Isolating languages like Mandarin Chinese)
3. Do such languages make a finite/nonfinite distinction? How relevant is it?



Subjectlessness

pro = null subject of finite clauses

PRO = null subject of nonfinite clauses



- “The usual criteria apply to determine whether a clause is finite or infinitival: roughly, a finite clause contains a finite verb or INFL and a lexical subject; an infinitival clause does not contain a finite verb or INFL and cannot – usually – contain a lexical subject” (Koopman 1986, p. 235)
 - $\text{Mari}_i \text{ vle } \text{PRO}_{i/*j} *te \text{ vini}$ Mary wants to come over
 - $\text{Mari}_i \text{ fè } \text{I}_{*i/j} *te \text{ vini}$ Mary makes him/her come over
 - $\text{Mari}_i \text{ vle } \text{I}_{*i/j} *te \text{ vini}$ Mary wants him/her to come over
 - $\text{Mari}_i \text{ vle pou } \text{I}_{i/j} (te) \text{ vini}$ Mary wants (him/her) to come over
- Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989, p. 308) : if “I” is subject, would it be an exceptional case?

Tenselessness



- [HC] Mari_i fè l_{*i/j} ***te** vini *Mary makes him/her come over*
- [HC] Mari_i vle PRO_{i/*j} ***te** vini *Mary wants to come over*
- [HC] Mari_i vle l_{*i/j} ***te** vini *Mary wants him/her to come over*

- [HC] Mari_i vle pou l_{i/j} **(te)** vini *Mary wants (him/her) to come over*
- [HC] Mari dwe **te** vini *Mary must have arrived*
- [MC] Mari dwet **té** vini *Mary must have arrived*

- *How to tell the presence or absence of INFL without referring to an a-prioristic decision? (WH-extraction and binding principles)*
- Should the complement of **dwe(t)** be considered finite? But it does not host a possible lexical subject

Complementizer licensing



- [HC] Mari_i vle **pou** I_{i/j} (te) pati
leave

Mary wants him/her to have left/ to

- [HC] Mari_i vle I_{*i/j} (*te) pati

Mary wants him/her to have left

But...

- [HC] Mari dwe ***pou/*ke** te vini

Mary must have arrived

- [MC] Mari lé **(ki)** Jan ***té** pati.

Mary wants John to have left

- *Complementizer licensing is not a reliable variable to determine finiteness*



Finiteness cannot be determined :

Morphologically :

- No distinct finite and infinitive forms in Indo-European Pidgins and Creoles

Syntactically :

- Koopman's tests are circuitous and a-prioristic
 - The absence of an overt subject : what of imperatives and expletives?
 - The absence of an overt complementizer : what of optional complementizers?
 - The inability to host TMA markers: what of the case of modal verbs?



Approach to research

- Use recent theoretical considerations that study finiteness outside its morphological confines.
- Leveling the playing field and allow cross-linguistic comparisons with other languages by invoking typologies traditionally associated with finite and non-finite clauses.
- Develop research methodology allowing for a diachronic study of MC and HC, and a synchronic study between MC and HC (grammars, dictionaries, Corpus, surveys)
- Allow Creole language study outside of a solely variationist perspective





Theoretical considerations

Finiteness in Creoles and other languages



Theoretical Contributions



- Bianchi (2003) : the syntax-semantics interface of finiteness
- Landau (2004) : setting subject licensing and tensedness apart
- Adger (2007) : Complement size matters
- Wurmbrand (2014, 2015) : Not all infinitives are equal
- Redefining tensedness outside of morphological marking
 - All finite clauses are tensed, but not all tensed clauses are finite
 - A tensed clause is a clause with a non-anaphorical temporal specification
 - A finite clause must be defined beyond its ability to license tense

Complementation System and tense



Finite/nonfinite distinction + fine-grained distinctions between complements

Indicative	Finite – full CP – pro/lexical DP - Independent tense <i>He says [that he will leave tomorrow / that he left yesterday]</i>
Subjunctive	Finite – full CP – pro/lexical DP - Dependent tense/future-oriented <i>It is necessary [that you be on time tomorrow / *that you were on time yesterday] Il est nécessaire [que tu sois à l'heure demain / *que tu aies été à l'heure hier]</i>
Partial control	Non-finite – full CP – PRO - Dependent tense/future-oriented <i>He prefers [to leave tomorrow / *to have left yesterday]</i>
ECM/raising	Non-finite – CP-truncated – Trace - Dependent tense/tensed <i>Anson believes Jill [*to call tomorrow / to have called yesterday]</i>
Exhaustive control	Non-finite – TP-truncated – Trace/PRO - Anaphoric tense/tenseless <i>*John begins [to leave tomorrow / to have left yesterday]</i>

Research questions



- Can we identify different complement types in MC and HC?
- Can we identify properties of indicative/subjunctive clauses that differ from the other complement types?
- Can all complement types found in MC and HC be defined by the current theoretical contributions?

Expanding the analysis



- Look at negation licensing and extend analysis to more predicate types
 - **Modal verbs** : *must / be able to*
 - **Raising verbs** : *to seem*
 - **Particular creole structures** : *fok (one must/il faut que)*
 - **Existential/weather verbs** : *there is / il fait beau, chaud, froid (it's pretty out, hot, cold)*
- Collect novel data, check the relevance of past analyses, find more evidence (diachronically and synchronically)
 - MC and HC Grammars/dictionaries & corpus collection
 - Acceptability judgments from NS

Corpus and Questionnaire



- Corpus (2002 – 2022)
- Martinican Creole : 18 MC creole authors / News articles and blog posts / ~14k types / ~280k tokens
- Haitian Creole : Wiki pages and news articles / ~42k types / ~1.7M tokens
- Acceptability judgment survey
 - ~ 40 sentences to judge
 - Context + sentence to judge
 - Likert scale 1 – 5

1 / 4 Ki manniè ou ké jijé fraz-tala daprè konteks-la?

< >

Kontèks: Pyè té tjit poul pou manjé oswè-a mé man pa enmen poul.

Fraz:
"Man lé pa manjé poul-la."

- ☐ 1. Fraz-la pa akseptab pies
- ☐ 2. Fraz-la pa telman akseptab
- ☐ 3. Ni yon ni lot
- ☐ 4. Fraz-la tibren akseptab
- ☐ 5. Fraz-la akseptab toubonnman



Findings

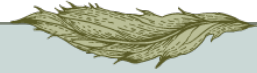


Findings per predicate



	What I found	What it tells us
To make	- Two types of complements instead of one	- Indicative vs. Exhaustive control clauses - Potential semantic evidence for finite/nonfinite distinction
To want	- Two types of nonfinite complements that are actually both partial control	- Subjunctive vs. Partial control clauses - Subject licensing and negation as only finiteness markers
Modals	- Deontic modals are exhaustive control - Epistemic modals are raising - Possible language change in progress for MC deontic <i>pé</i>	- Exhaustive control vs. Raising clauses
To seem	- Prototypical finite complements in HC - New RtoS HC form challenges current theories	- Indicative clauses
One_must	- Morphological markedness in MC - Motivations for scopal relations	- Indicative clauses and Subjunctive clauses
Impersonal Expressions	- Null-subject properties in Creoles	- Finiteness and subject licensing need to include referentiality

Fè - Indicative-like vs. Control clauses



Nonfinite *fè* : exhaustive control properties
no zero-marker - marginal vP negation –
PRO - anaphorical temporal specification

[HC] Jan fè l **pa** vini - *John makes him not come over*

[MC] “Ou té ka **fè kò'w** pasé pou fanm ki pli dwet
asou late” - *You **were making yourself** be perceived
as the most righteous woman on Earth*

[MC] “Sé té pou **fè nou pa bliyé** té ni 300 lanné di sa
...” - *It was to **make us not forget** that 300 years
ago*

(new) *Finite fè* : Indicative-like properties
zero-marker - sentential negation –
nominative subject - independent temporal specification

[HC] “Se sa k **fè yo te ka** vann 5000 CD” - *That's what made
it so that **they were able** to sell 5000 CD*

[MC] “Sé pas Lariviè-Salé té bouché dépi jédi-oswè ki **fè man
pa pran** la penn désann” - *It's because Lariviè-Salé was
blocked since Thursday night that made it so that **I didn't
bother** coming down*

Vle/lé - Subjunctive vs. Partial Control



Finite *vle/lé* Subjunctive-like properties
no zero-marker - **sentential negation** -
nominative/free subject - dependent temporal specification

[MC] Man lé (ki) *man/Jan pa* fè gaspiyaj

[HC] Mwen vle pou *m/Jan pa* gate poul la
- *I want for me/John to waste (the chicken)*

(Mostly acceptable)

[MC] Mari lé (ki) *Pyè *té* péché pwason (epi'y yè)

[HC] Mari vle pou *Pyè *te* ale peche pwason (avè l yè)
- *Mary wants for Peter to have gone fishing (with her yesterday)*

HC Nonfinite *vle/lé*: Partial-control properties
no zero-marker - **marginal vP negation** –
PRO - dependent temporal specification

[HC] Mari_i vle *l_{i/j}* #pa vini - *Mary wants (him/her) to not come over*
(Mostly unacceptable)

[HC] Mari_i vle *l_{*i/j}* *te vini - *Mary wants him/her to come over*

Semantic analysis via corpus search and acceptability judgments for meaning inference

Sanm/sanble - Indicative vs. Raising



Finite sanm/sanble: Indicative-like properties

- zero-marker - **nominative subject**
(pronominal copy) - independent temporal specification

- [MC] “Kannaval-la ka sanm **l** bien pati” – *The Carnival seems to be off to a good start*
- [HC] “Li sanble **li** toujou kenbe yon wòl enpòtan” – *He seems to always hold an important role*
- [MC] Mark ka sanm i **té ké** lé travay épi Mari
- [HC] Mark sanble l **ta** vle travay avè Mari
- *It seems that Mark would like to work with Mary*

(new) Nonfinite sanble: RtoS and indicative properties
- no zero-marker - **trace (covert anaphoric subject)** -
(in)dependent temporal specification

- [HC] “Jij Mécène sanble **[t]** te kriye pou ryen” – *“Judge Mécène seems to have cried for nothing”*
- [HC] “Pwoblèm sa, menm si li sanble **[t]** pa deranje [eta...” – *“The problem, even if it doesn’t seem to bother the State...”*
- [HC] Mark sanble ta vle travay ak mwen
- [MC] Mark ka sanm té ké lé travay épi mwen

– not attested in corpus, but acceptable by NS
May be an artifact of the survey or a sign of language change in progress with covert Pronominal copy

Modals – Exhaustive control and Raising



Bernabé (1983), DeGraff (1992) and Syea (2017)

- If TMA/negation post-position, then modal is epistemic
 - Raising – CP-truncated, vP negation, dependent tense
- If TMA/negation pre-position, then modal is deontic
 - Exhaustive Control – TP-truncated, negation is sentential, anaphorical tense
- Allows to properly account for language change and split the modals from one another
 - Post-verbal negation in MC *pé* and HC *ka*
- By attributing a particular complement structure, one can seek a verb movement hypothesis

	Deontic (perm. ,oblig., abil.)	Epistemic (judg. on prop.)
TMA	[MC] Pyè [té dwet] vini (11) [HC] Pyè [te dwe] vini (65) <i>Peter had to come</i> <i>Pierre devait venir</i>	[MC] Pyè [dwet té] vini (3) [HC] Pyè [dwe te] vini (1) <i>Peter must have come</i> <i>Pierre doit être venu</i>
Neg	[MC] Pyè [pa pé] vini (17) [HC] Pyè [pa ka] vini (444) <i>Peter cannot come</i> <i>Pierre (ne) peut pas venir</i>	[MC] Pyè [pé pa] vini (229) [HC] Pyè [ka pa] vini (31) <i>Peter is able to not come</i> <i>Pierre peut (ne) pas venir</i>

Back to our case studies



- | | | |
|---|------------------------------------|----------------------|
| • Mari _i fè l _{*i/j} *(te) vini | Mary makes him/her come over | → Exhaustive control |
| • Mari _i vle PRO _{i/*j} vini | Mary wants to come over | → Partial control |
| • Mari _i vle l _{*i/j} *(te) vini | Mary wants him/her to come over | → Partial control |
| • Mari _i vle pu l _{i/j} te/*ta vini | Mary wants (him) to have come over | → Subjunctive-like |
| • Mari di ke l te/ta vini | Mary says she will come/came over | → Indicative-like |

Finiteness Beyond Morphology



- Finiteness as clause size : A finite clause is a full-CP with a free overt subject, a non-anaphorical temporal specification and sentential negation
 - The case of HC *sanble* and MC *fok* challenges these considerations
- Provides a strong theoretical basis to the study of Creoles
 - Provides analytical and theoretical basis for study of language change for MC modal and *fok* and HC *sanble*
 - Can be analyzed in isolation rather than in relation to the lexifier language
- Corpus analysis and survey designs to allow deeper semantic analysis
 - Semantic/pragmatic distinction between finite/nonfinite *fè*
 - Deontic and epistemic modals in MC and HC
- Possible comparisons with other creoles or other isolating languages (e.g. Mandarin Chinese)
- Unanswered questions motivate for description of Creoles in Corpus Linguistics and NLP (dependencies 220 sentences/ 4809 tokens)



Thank you



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